MONTANA

The Treasure State



The Bitterroot Valley has always known how to feed people. Stretching nearly ninety miles through western Montana between the Bitterroot and Sapphire mountain ranges, this broad river corridor was home to the Salish people—known also as the Flathead—for centuries before European contact. They were expert hunters who followed the seasonal movements of elk through the high meadows and timbered ridges, reading the landscape the way others read a map. Elk was not simply food to the Salish. It was sustenance, ceremony, and survival woven into a single animal. Every part was used—the meat dried and preserved for winter, the hide turned to clothing and shelter, the bones shaped into tools. Nothing was wasted, and nothing was taken lightly.

Come late summer, the women and children moved through the mountain slopes gathering huckleberries—Vaccinium membranaceum—the small, ink-dark fruit that ripened in the high elevations between 3,500 and 7,000 feet, preferring the disturbed forest edges where sunlight broke through the timber. Huckleberries could not be tamed into cultivation. They grew wild and on their own terms, which is precisely what made them precious. The Salish dried them, mixed them with elk meat and fat to make pemmican, and carried that dense, nourishing food through the long Montana winters and on trading journeys east across the Continental Divide onto the northern plains.

When Lewis and Clark passed through the Bitterroot Valley in September of 1805, they were met by the Salish near present-day Lolo, Montana—hungry, exhausted, and deeply relieved. The Salish fed them, traded horses with them, and guided them westward. Meriwether Lewis recorded the encounter in his journals, noting the generosity of the people and the unfamiliar but welcome food placed before his party. The expedition's journals also documented huckleberries throughout the region, one of many native foods that sustained the Corps of Discovery through some of its most punishing terrain.

By the latter half of the 1800s, Montana's elk herds and wild berry patches had drawn a new wave of settlers—ranchers, miners, and homesteaders pushing into the Bitterroot and the Flathead valleys, the Beartooth foothills, and the wide grasslands surrounding Great Falls. For these families, elk hunting was not sport but necessity, and huckleberries gathered each August filled jars that lined cellar shelves through the bitter winter months. The pairing of wild game and wild berry became the rhythm of Montana life—deeply practical, and quietly beautiful.

That tradition has never left. Walk into any hunting camp in the Rockies in October, or any Montana kitchen in late summer, and you will still find some version of this combination on the stove. The deep, gamey richness of elk meets the tartness of huckleberries in a way that feels less like a recipe and more like a conversation between the land and the people who have always lived on it. When you make this dish, you are pulling from one of the longest-running culinary traditions in North America—one written not in cookbooks, but in the memory of mountains, seasons, and a people who understood this place long before anyone else arrived to name it.

This one is worth savoring slowly.

ELK BURGERS WITH SPICY HUCKLEBERRY BBQ SAUCE

In Montana, where bull elk roam the high meadows and wild huckleberries purple the mountainsides each August, it was only a matter of time before someone pressed the two together into a burger that tastes like the Rockies themselves.

Yield: 4 burgers

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INGREDIENTS

- 1 lb. ground elk
- ¼ cup breadcrumbs
- ¼ cup butter
- 1 egg
- 1 Tbsp Worcestershire sauce
- Salt and pepper, to taste
- 4 hamburger buns

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Form the patties*: In a bowl, mix all ingredients. Be sure not to omit the butter—elk is very lean, and the butter is needed to bring out the flavor and juiciness of the burger. Form the mixture into patties.
2. *Grill*: Preheat your grill to medium-high. Cook the patties for 4–5 minutes on each side, or until they reach your desired doneness (we prefer ours medium—160°F / 71°C).
3. *Serve*: Place the burgers on buns, generously top with huckleberry BBQ sauce, and enjoy the sweet taste of Montana's wild essence in each delicious bite.

Serve with Spicy Huckleberry BBQ Sauce (page 130).

SPICY HUCKLEBERRY BBQ SAUCE

Yield: 2 cups

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INGREDIENTS

- 1 cup huckleberries
- 1 cup ketchup
- ¼ cup brown sugar
- 1 Tbsp apple cider vinegar
- 1 tsp garlic powder
- 1 Tbsp hot sauce
- 1 tsp chipotle pepper powder
- Salt and pepper, to taste

For those that cannot tolerate spicy foods, simply omit the hot sauce and chipotle pepper from the Spicy Huckleberry BBQ Sauce recipe.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Simmer*: In a saucepan over medium heat, combine all ingredients. Simmer for 10–15 minutes, mashing the huckleberries as they cook until the sauce thickens. Set aside.

